

Report on the outcomes of a Short-Term Scientific Mission¹

Action number: CA21129

Grantee name: Agnieszka Hess

Details of the STSM

Title: **Expert-influencers as catalysts of public opinion: A multimodal analysis of opinion negotiation in Poland**

Start and end date: 02/06/2026 to 09/06/2026

Description of the work carried out during the STSM

During the Short-Term Scientific Mission (STSM) at the Department of Communication, National University of Political Studies and Public Administration (SNSPA) in Bucharest, Romania, significant progress was made on the joint investigation into expert-influencers. Collaborating directly with Dr. Elena Negrea-Busuioc, the initial phase of the residency focused on reviewing and refining the primary dataset of 2025 YouTube videos featuring Polish political commentators. Following a rigorous evaluation of the data's alignment with the research objectives, the sample was structurally adjusted: Patrycjusz Wyżga was discarded from the dataset to better focus the comparative analysis.

The core scientific achievement of the visit was the collaborative development of a comprehensive, multimodal coding scheme designed to annotate the finalized video dataset and directly answer the project's research questions. To address how Polish expert-influencers construct their status as "positioned speakers" (RQ1), the coding grid was designed to operationalize several linguistic and multimodal strategies. The coding scheme captures "epistemic action", noting linguistic authority through data appeals (citing polls, historical precedents, or statistics) and specialist terminology, as well as epistemic stances like neutral distancing. It also specifically tracks "positional slippage", identifying moments when hosts or guests inadvertently adopt partisan positions. Furthermore, the scheme captures critical non-verbal communication, including vocalic cues (didactic pacing, emotional register, and turn-taking/interruption), kinesic cues (mapping manual gestures, proximity/leaning posture), and mimics (affective displays such as disdain, amusement, seriousness, or alarm).

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To address the dominant thematic clusters and public opinion negotiation (RQ2), the coding scheme deeply maps out the thematic architecture of the broadcasts. It categorizes agenda-setting elements, including the specific interview hook, the host frame (e.g., Rymanowski's premise), and guest deflections or redirections. The grid further details candidate evaluations, specifically tracking the framing of Nawroski versus opposing candidates based on their traits. It also categorizes political actions (programmatic critiques of policy and performative critiques of campaigns) and dimensions of broader political polarization, both ideological and affective. Importantly, the coding grid also includes a negotiation layer to evaluate how speakers define the boundaries of normative legitimacy and acceptance within the public sphere.

Another important part of the visit was planning joint conference presentations aimed at disseminating the concept and the results of the ongoing research. A working draft of the presentation has been prepared, in which the conceptual framework of the ongoing comparative research will be presented.

Description of the STSM main achievements and planned follow-up activities

The research progress made during this stay lays the foundation for a co-authored manuscript targeted at a peer-reviewed international journal.

The first conference presentation (Expert-influencers as catalysts of public opinion in the digital age. Conceptualizing Comparative Research) is scheduled for October 2026 at the annual conference (Knowledge-Communication-Action), organized in Kraków by the Institute of Journalism, Media, and Social Communication at Jagiellonian University.

Beyond the core empirical work, the STSM involved institutional networking and academic integration. There were some meetings with faculty administrators and researchers, conducting studies on public opinion.

In terms of long-term collaborative follow-up activities, substantial plans were established to deepen the academic and cultural ties between Poland and Romania. The idea of creation a new annual workshops entitled "Polish-Romanian Dialogues" was discussed. It is important to involve institutions such as the Polish Institute in Romania, the City of Kraków, and the Polish-Romanian Society in Kraków in their organization. The workshops are to be held annually, alternating between Bucharest and Kraków, with the inaugural edition scheduled for 2027. The primary objective of this annual gathering is to further sustainable, long-term cultural cooperation and intellectual exchange between scholars, researchers, and other experts specializing in the field of communication.

To get this initiative off the ground, contacts have been established with the Polish Institute in Bucharest.